

Chapter 34-2: Close Person

After about half the time it takes to burn a stick of incense, Ning Fuyi finally felt somewhat better. As she got up to change clothes, she walked to the bronze mirror and curiously touched the blood scabs on her lips with her hand.

How could there be so much blood? Could it be that she had also vomited blood yesterday?

At this moment, the door was suddenly knocked on. Liu Wenzhu, who had slept well through the night and was refreshed, ran in wearing her door robes, saying softly with a smile: "Yiyi¹, you got up so early. When I came back last night and saw you sleeping, I thought you must be very tired from the journey."

She had barely finished speaking when she stopped in surprise: "Why is there so much blood on your face? What happened last night?"

She quickly stepped forward and waved her sleeve, removing the blood scabs to reveal Ning Fuyi's originally fair skin.

"It's nothing, nothing. Perhaps the spiritual energy at Zhaoyang Mountain is too strong, and I wasn't used to it for a moment, so I had a nosebleed." Ning Fuyi answered with a smile. It was better that such things remained unknown. Considering Chu Qingqiu's character that couldn't tolerate even a grain of sand, she must have already punished Li Hanyan.

It's just that she seemed to be seriously injured yesterday...

Thinking of this, she immediately shifted her thoughts. Chu Qingqiu's injuries had nothing to do with her, and it wasn't something she could manage. Having helped her once yesterday was already being benevolent and righteous.

"Alright then." Liu Wenzhu believed her words and reached out to help arrange her hair. "Hurry and change clothes. The senior brothers and sisters are all waiting outside."

"Is the Zhaoyang Conference starting now?" Ning Fuyi asked in surprise.

"It should have been tomorrow, but the Zhaoyang Saintess just sent out invitations, asking all sect leaders and disciples to go to Zhaoyang Peak, saying she wants everyone to enjoy some entertainment together before the conference begins." Liu Wenzhu answered, her expression also somewhat puzzled. "I wonder what kind of entertainment it is."

Although Ning Fuyi was quite uninterested, she still went out with Liu Wenzhu and joined the Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate team, heading to Zhaoyang Peak.

This was the highest place in all of Zhaoyang Mountain, capable of accommodating millions of disciples. After reaching the summit, one could no longer see flying birds, and in the distance was all swirling mist, with occasional divine mountains showing their peaks, like a painting.

Although only elite disciples had come to Zhaoyang Mountain, besides the six major sects, there were many cultivation sects in the martial world. After forming a circle, it was still a magnificent sight with countless heads.

A circle of high platforms was built around the vast Zhaoyang Peak for everyone to sit on. The sect leaders' seats were at the front, followed by the seats for other disciples, all made of jade stone with fruits, tea, and water arranged on top, providing thoughtful hospitality.

Among them, the positions of the six major sects were the most elevated, while those of the smaller sects were lower, arranged in a staggered fashion.

Ning Fuyi and Liu Wenzhu, pulling Rong Jin along, found a place with a good view to sit down. This high platform was built very cleverly - just by sitting, one could see everything below clearly.

Mei Chengsi and the three elders had already taken their seats in front. People frequently came and went, greeting each other. Mei Chengsi was just stroking his beard and smiling proudly when someone suddenly called out, and the crowd that had been surrounding him all turned in another direction, surrounding the late-arriving Chu Qingqiu.

Ning Fuyi's gaze lingered on Chu Qingqiu. She was still dressed in white, with flying feathers embroidered in silver thread on her skirt hem and sleeves, and cloud shoulders in the shape of flying birds on her shoulders, looking quite imposing.

She politely nodded to everyone but didn't say much. Although her complexion was pale, it was clear, showing no sign of having been seriously injured.

The other six sects also took their seats one by one. Ning Fuyi didn't see Li Hanyan anywhere, only a few disciples sitting alone in their positions.

Chu Qingqiu must have already taught her a lesson. Ning Fuyi curled her lips slightly, hoping Chu Qingqiu had been even more heavy-handed to compensate for her not being able to get the Emei Thorn.

When everyone was seated and the vast Zhaoyang Peak presented a magnificent scene, the ground in the distance suddenly rippled like water, and the figure of a white-bearded old man appeared. He opened his mouth slightly, and his voice traveled across the great distance to reach everyone's ears.

"We are greatly honored by your presence at Zhaoyang Mountain. However, the Saintess is indisposed and temporarily unable to come out of seclusion to welcome you, so she has instructed this old one to receive everyone. We hope for your understanding."

"The Saintess was concerned that you might be bored, so before the conference begins, she has set up some small competitions. Participants will be randomly selected from the disciples of each sect, and the winner will receive a bottle of Cloud-Chasing Sacred Water². This competition is not part of the main conference, so everyone can rest assured."

Cloud-Chasing Sacred Water was the Saintess's tears, a sacred medicine for healing injuries that was priceless. For ordinary disciples, it was a treasure. As soon as these words were spoken, the ordinary disciples with lower cultivation levels excitedly began to chatter.

The Zhaoyang Conference had always been an occasion for each sect to enhance their prestige and reputation, especially as it determined the ranking of the six major sects' strength in the martial world. For some smaller sects, if their disciples stood out at the Zhaoyang Conference, it would also mean the spread of their fame. Therefore, the Zhaoyang Conference was always highly valued every year.

Although this competition was small, with thousands of eyes watching, they absolutely couldn't afford to lose face.

As people's thoughts stirred, the white-bearded old man spoke again: "Everyone can see the tea cups on your tables. If you lift the lid and auspicious clouds rise up, please stand here. Each sect will select one person."

As soon as he finished speaking, crisp sounds of opening lids rang out all around, with continuous exclamations and screams as auspicious clouds rose from the sea of people.

The selected disciples were either excited or afraid, but they all stood up and walked down from the high platform.

"Who is it from Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate?" disciples around were asking. However, as lid after lid was opened, no one was selected. In the end, even several elders turned around to look, glancing at each other in confusion.

Rong Jin and Liu Wenzhu both opened their lids, but inside was only a cup of clear tea with no auspicious clouds. Ning Fuyi had a bad premonition and frowned tightly.

"Yours hasn't been opened yet." Feng Ge, sitting in front, suddenly spoke, looking at Ning Fuyi with an unpleasant expression.

Ning Fuyi glanced at her, reached out and flicked open the lid. Immediately, a huge auspicious cloud emerged, shooting straight up into the sky, completely exposing her to everyone's view.

"Look, it's Ning Fuyi!" Someone turned to look at Ning Fuyi, with a face full of regret.

"How could it be her? It's over. Before the Zhaoyang Conference even begins, our Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate is going to lose face."

"Yiyi..." Liu Wenzhu quickly grabbed Ning Fuyi's sleeve, but Ning Fuyi gave her a reassuring smile and stood up to walk down.

Countless gazes seemed to focus on her, some mocking, some worrying about Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate's inevitable defeat. Occasionally she heard a few murmurs, but when Ning Fuyi looked over, those people would look down at their noses and focus on their hearts³.

Chu Qingqiu wasn't looking at her but was gazing thoughtfully at the platform below. Ning Fuyi's gaze swept over her as she straightened her back and walked directly toward the distant old man.

After everyone gathered, there were fifteen disciples present in total. The oldest was from Tianji Sword Sect, a man with sword-like brows and starry eyes, dressed magnificently and carrying a rare precious sword. The one from Guijian Sect was a thin young man with a stiff body and a dark 印堂⁴. The one from Hehuan Sect was a beautiful woman who was touching the spiritual artifact in her hands with complete disdain.

An ordinary-looking young woman squeezed up behind Ning Fuyi and whispered to her: "Fellow immortal, are you afraid?"

"Not afraid." Ning Fuyi shook her head. What use was fear? Besides, the Zhaoyang Conference hadn't even started yet - this was just an appetizer.

"My heart is very flustered. Look at them - they're all outstanding talents. Their cultivation must all be at the Transformation Realm or above..."

As soon as she finished speaking, the white-bearded old man suddenly raised his sleeve and summoned a rainbow. The arched rainbow immediately became a large door, with the scene inside blurry and unclear, looking like some kind of wild beast.

"This is the Nightmare Beast⁵, an exotic beast that the Saintess captured at Tongchuan. It can pull you all into illusions. If you can break out of the illusion, you win. If you can't break out, you fail. But rest assured, this exotic beast is not a fierce beast and will not harm your lives." The white-bearded old man said with a smile, then extended his hand in a gesture of invitation.

The fifteen disciples looked at each other and walked through the arched door one by one, their bodies disappearing from their original spots. Then the arched door suddenly became larger, large enough for those sitting in the back to see the scenes on it clearly. At the same time, the screen divided into fifteen parts, each showing the faces of the fifteen disciples who had entered.

There was a sound of gasps from the crowd, all very amazed.

"I forgot to tell everyone - this Nightmare Beast has a peculiar trait: its illusions don't welcome solitary people, so it will summon the most intimate and important person present to each of you to enter."

As soon as he finished speaking, people began disappearing from the high platform one by one, then appeared in the scenes within the arched door with shocked expressions.

The most important person? Ning Fuyi, who was already standing in complete darkness, heard the words from outside. It must be Liu Wenzhu, she thought, crossing her arms.

At the same time, Liu Wenzhu on the high platform also prepared herself, gripping the magical artifact in her hand.

"Divine Venerable, this year's Zhaoyang Conference is indeed different, with so many elaborate arrangements. This Zhaoyang Saintess must have changed her nature after wandering the human world for ten years." Elder Yuanming said with a smile while holding his tea cup. However, as soon as he looked up, he froze in place.

"Chu Ling Divine Venerable?" He blinked, simultaneously drawing the attention of others, who all stared at Chu Qingqiu's suddenly empty seat, not understanding what had happened.

"Look quickly! There!" Someone pointed at the arched door and shouted loudly.

So everyone looked up together and discovered with shock and fear that the famous Chu Ling Divine Venerable was now standing in the scene, holding a cup of freshly poured tea with furrowed brows.

Author's Note: Exotic Beast: "If I had known, I would have died at Tongchuan."

Footnotes:

1. **Yiyi (衣衣)** - An affectionate nickname for Ning Fuyi, using the repeated last character of her name
2. **Cloud-Chasing Sacred Water (追云圣水)** - A precious healing elixir made from the Saintess's tears
3. **Look down at their noses and focus on their hearts** - A Chinese idiom meaning to mind one's own business and not get involved
4. **印堂 (Yintang)** - The area between the eyebrows, often referenced in Chinese medicine and fortune-telling; being dark suggests bad luck or evil influence
5. **Nightmare Beast (梦魔兽)** - A mythical creature that can create illusions and nightmares